

Gendered Evaluation in Entrepreneurship: A Literature-Based Inquiry into Gender Bias in Entrepreneurship

Group No. 5

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Introduction

Women's entrepreneurship in India begins with a striking contradiction: a country rich in talent but historically reluctant to let that talent lead. Kalpana Saroj was one of India's first and most successful businesswomen, even before the phrase "women founder" entered popular culture. She rebuilt the failing Kamani Tubes Company and turned it into a successful business after rising from extreme social and economic marginalization, proving that leadership is not inherited but rather developed with tenacity and strategic vision.

Yet, for many women who attempt to enter the world of business, the pathway remains obstructed. They are confronted to limited access to capital, gendered perceptions about risk-taking, exclusion from influential networks, and a persistent lack of institutional mentorship. Legal and bureaucratic systems, though improving, often demand navigation skills and resources that many first-generation women entrepreneurs struggle to access.

Today, India presents a mixed landscape. The country has witnessed a steady rise in women-led startups which supported by government schemes and shifting societal attitudes. However, women still constitute a small minority of business founders, and the scale of their enterprises remains comparatively modest. India's entrepreneurial ecosystem is evolving rapidly but its full potential will remain unrealised until women's leadership becomes the normal and not exception.

Research area

The research area of this study includes systematic literature review on gendered biases faced by women involved in business.

Explanation of keyword selection and search strategy

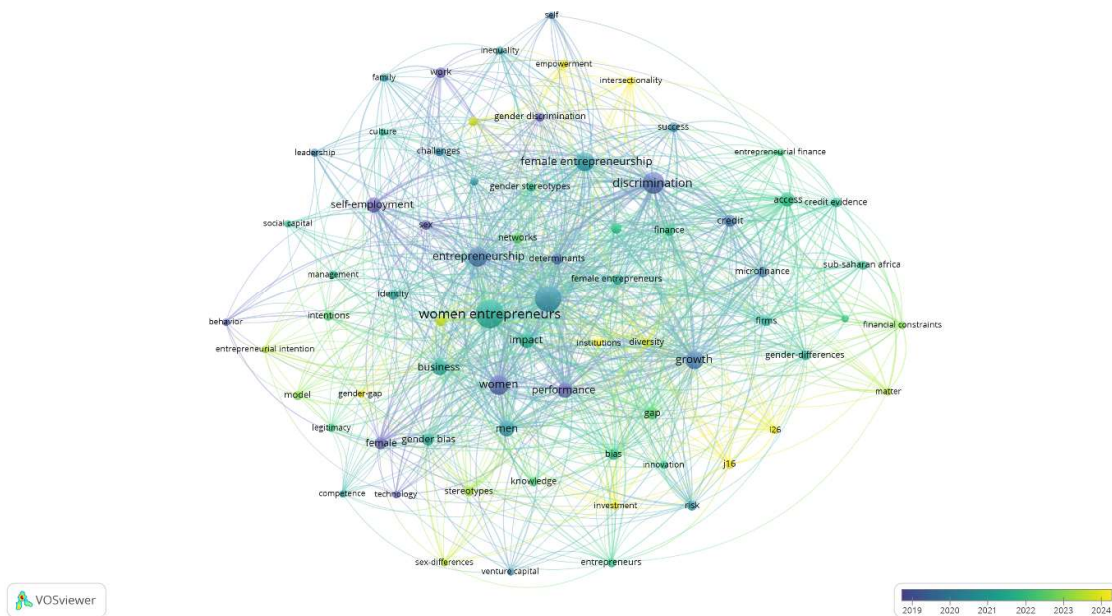
To explore The Politics of Calling Women-Led Enterprise 'Side Income', the search strategy focused on capturing literature that links women's entrepreneurship with the forces that undervalue their economic contributions. The final Web of Science query combined terms

representing women-led business activity (“women entrepreneurship,” “women entrepreneurs,” “women-led enterprises”) with terms representing structural and cultural barriers (“discrimination,” “bias,” “stereotype”). This Boolean combination ensured that the dataset included studies examining not just women’s business participation but also the social and institutional forces that label their work as secondary, informal or economically insignificant. This targeted approach produced a focused and relevant dataset for bibliometric analysis.

Summary of Web of Science dataset

After going through the keywords and coming up with a satisfactory query which is ("women entrepreneurship" OR "female entrepreneurship" OR "women entrepreneurs" OR "women owned businesses" OR "women led enterprises" OR "female owned business" OR "female led enterprise") AND ("Discrimination" OR "Bias" OR "Stereotype") we got 171 results. Then we refined our search by applying filters such as limiting the document type to review articles and research articles. From the Web of Science Categories dropdown, we selected Business, Economics, Women's Studies, Development Studies, Sociology, and Social Science Interdisciplinary.

VOSviewer analysis and visual findings



Source: VOSviewer

The overlay visualisation created in VOSviewer provides a clear picture of how research on women-led enterprises is organised around key themes and conceptual links. The colour coded map reveals clusters of closely connected keywords, showing where scholarly attention is concentrated and how different ideas relate to each other.

One noticeable cluster is formed around terms such as gender discrimination, gender stereotypes, sex differences, culture and family. Their close proximity indicates that a dominant part of the literature investigates how social norms and biased expectations shape the perception of women's entrepreneurial work. These studies highlight how women's enterprises are often labelled as "side income" because of entrenched assumptions about their primary roles within the household and society.

Another meaningful cluster appears through keywords like entrepreneurial intention, behavior, competence, knowledge, management and performance. This grouping suggests that researchers are also exploring the internal workings of women-led enterprises how women build confidence, make strategic decisions, acquire skills and manage their enterprises in restrictive social environments.

A third visible cluster focuses on access, credit, microfinance, financial constraints, innovation and risk. These themes indicate growing interest in understanding how financial systems and resource limitations affect the growth and legitimacy of women's businesses.

Overall, the VOSviewer visualisation shows that research in this field is shaped by three interconnected areas: gendered barriers, entrepreneurial behaviour and financial access, each influencing how women's enterprises are valued.

Key Literature Discussions

The literature we have got from the web of science shows that the first barrier is

Cost Disparity

According to the survey in the study, starting a business is more expensive for women than for males. Reducing these expenses through targeted incubation, subsidized capital access, or streamlined registration would significantly boost the number of businesses created by women. (Chiplunkar, 2024)

Investment Inequality

Second theme that is prominent from the obtained articles is difficult accessibility of capital and resources. Women entrepreneurs face biased perceptions right from the start: some investors and peers regard female-led ventures as inferior, which negatively affects funding, support, and growth opportunities. (Laguía et al., 2022)

Power Play

Another possible reason we found in many mid-market and large companies is that men still dominate leadership positions and progress toward gender balance is extremely slow. Because of which women continue to face barriers when advancing to senior positions. Despite growing awareness and diversity efforts, equal representation at the top remains uncommon, and women often struggle to attain the same status, influence, and recognition as their male counterparts which further slows down the cycle of female rising to senior positions. (Vazirani, 2025)

Thematic Evolution

In 2019–2020, darker blue nodes such as gender discrimination, gender stereotypes, sex differences, culture, family, and identity stand out. These early themes show that the initial scholarly focus was on uncovering the social and cultural forces that limit women entrepreneurs. Research during these years centered on how norms, stereotypes, and discrimination shaped the perception of women's enterprises as "side income," rather than legitimate economic activity.

Moving into 2021, represented by greenish tones, the network expands toward themes like entrepreneurial intention, behavior, management, knowledge, competence, business, performance, and growth. This shift indicates that researchers began exploring not only the barriers but also the internal dynamics of women-led ventures how women make decisions, build skills, navigate networks, and influence business outcomes. The conversation becomes more nuanced, moving beyond simply identifying inequality.

By 2022–2023, lighter green to yellow-green shades highlight themes such as access, credit, microfinance, financial constraints, innovation, risk, and firms. These keywords reveal a shift toward examining systemic and institutional factors especially financial access and the economic environment. Researchers in these years increasingly studied how structural conditions support or limit women's entrepreneurial growth.

Finally, in 2024 which is shown in bright yellow, highlights emerging areas like intersectionality, empowerment, success, impact insub-Saharan Africa, and diversity. These recent themes reflect a stronger, future-focused narrative: women entrepreneurs are being studied in terms of their transformative potential, resilience, and broader social impact.

Overall, the period 2019–2024 shows a clear evolution from exposing discrimination, to analyzing enterprise behavior, to understanding systemic access, and finally toward recognising empowerment and growth. This shift challenges the long-standing idea of women's enterprises as merely "side income" and positions them as crucial drivers of economic and social change.

Proposed Research Idea and Justification

We stumbled upon this topic from reading about this topic from a YouTube video on the internet. It made us realize that this biasness happens so commonly around us yet we turn a blind eye towards it. This subtle form of gendered power hierarchy creeps its way in small actions and makes way to some very big decisions. Our main question is why is merit/capabilities of a person ignored when gender comes in play. Women from the beginning have not been allowed to move beyond household chores. Even if they do enter the world of business, they have to break the glass ceiling on each and every step. When their male counterparts just have to prove their business acumen, they have to prove whether they aren't too emotional or they won't take too many leaves and will behave "professionally". When the criteria used to evaluate male and female entrepreneurs differ, how can true equality exist? This is why this research topic is important.

References

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Group contribution:

Aditi Sharma:- Research Topic, Writeup (Introduction, Summary of Web of Science, Key Literature Discussions, Proposed Research idea and Justification) and Web of Science query keyword

Ravi Pratap Singh:-Web of Science query search and keyword, VOSViewer chart and Writeup(Explanation of keyword selection and search strategy, VOSviewer analysis and visual findings, Thematic Evolution)

Arhant Doongarwal:- Discussion of Topic